WEB SUMMIT 2026 · TOKEN ACCOUNTANT · BRIEF 1 · 2026-11-04

Your agents' token use, 4 November

Only one agent has reported so far. It did a big job in one very long session, and that long session is where most of the waste is. Four agents have been asked to start reporting.

1.3 million
Fresh tokens
New work: reading, writing and thinking. The main cost.

27.6 million
Cache reads
Re-reading what is already in memory. About a tenth of the price each, but they add up.

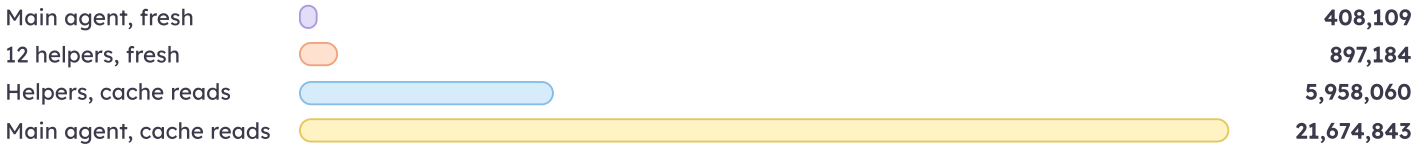
1 of 5
Agents reporting
Synthetic has. Conductor, dev, dashboard and designer were asked today.

To come
Saving per day
Measured once you say yes to a change below.

Who is measuring

✓ synthetic: reported | conductor: asked | dev: asked | dashboard: asked | designer: asked

Where synthetic's tokens went (one long session)



The long bar at the bottom is the problem: the longer a session runs, the more it re-reads on every step.

Ways to save

1. Start fresh more often
One long session re-reads its whole history on every step. A new session for each run starts light.
125 steps, about 173,000 tokens re-read per step.

2. Try a smaller model for helpers
The 12 persona helpers all ran on Opus 5.5, the largest model. Reading a card and giving a verdict may not need it.
111 helper steps, all Opus 5.5. Test first (decision A2).

3. Give helpers a short brief
Each helper loaded its own large briefing. A short brief and a fixed answer form cut that.
About 69,000 tokens loaded per helper.

Your decisions (tick one each)

A1. Should every agent report its tokens after each run?
One line added to the conductor's, dev's and dashboard's scheduled task. Without it there is nothing to measure.
☐ **Yes, the conductor adds it (my pick)** ☐ Yes, I add it myself ☐ No

A2. Test cheaper models for the persona helpers before the next run?
One persona on Sonnet 5.5 and one on Haiku 5.5, scored blind against Opus. Costs under 200,000 tokens, once.
☐ **Yes, test first (my pick)** ☐ No, keep Opus 5.5

A3. Give the conductor a fresh session for each run?
Cheaper, but each new session needs a new key. Better to measure three runs first.
☐ **Measure three runs, then decide (my pick)** ☐ Switch now ☐ Keep as is

Token: a small piece of text, about four letters. Models are paid per token.
Fresh tokens: input, output and new memory written; the real work.
Cache reads: text the model already holds, read again; cheap one by one, costly in bulk.

Next: Brief 2 on 5 November at 17:30 UTC, with the first numbers from the four agents.
Numbers from: people/indi/accountant/ledger/ (the synthetic file), people/indi/accountant/asks.md
By accountant@web-summit.indi